

During the Vietnam War, Black Americans' traditional support for military service began to wane, and by 1969, 56 percent of Black Americans opposed the war. Many of those already fighting for civil rights turned their voices against the draft, with organizations such as the Black Panthers and the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) denouncing the war. One Black man evaded the draft by fleeing to Canada—calling himself not a draft dodger but a runaway slave. Generally, people of color were more likely than white Americans to oppose the war in Vietnam, because they saw it as exploitative.

Unfair draft

The Selective Service system was rife with inequality. An individual's draft status was determined at the local level, where young Black men had to plead their cases to all-white draft boards that tended to bestow exemptions and deferrals onto more "promising" white college students. There were no Black Americans on draft boards in Alabama, Arkansas, Mississippi, or Louisiana, and one member of a Louisiana draft board was even a Grand Wizard of the Ku Klux Klan.

Tensions grow

The assassination of civil rights leader Martin Luther King Jr. in 1968 was a turning point for Black Americans, inciting many to violence out of anger and grief. In Vietnam, some white soldiers openly celebrated Dr. King's death: a group dressed as Klansmen paraded around the base at Cam Ranh Bay, and Confederate flags were hoisted with pride.

In contested areas, where the potential for violence made unity and brotherhood an operational necessity, race relations were mostly good, and some men found that the experience of battle had caused deeply held prejudices to be cast aside. However, in rearward areas and bases such as Long Binh, where life was quieter, racial tensions rose to the surface.